

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Zephaniah

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“The great Day of the LORD is near ... That day will be ... a day of destruction and desolation, a day of darkness and gloom...” (Zephaniah 1:14–15). Zephaniah’s words are frightening. Will the day of the LORD mean the end of everything? Zephaniah’s prophecy describes God’s coming judgment. But it also gives a promise. One day, God’s faithful people will live in a world full of righteousness and joy forever.

Setting

Zephaniah lived during a time of great change. Near the end of the Assyrian king Ashurbanipal’s last military campaigns, King Amon apparently led Judah in a large revolt against Assyria. Many countries west of Assyria took part in this revolt. Ashurbanipal acted quickly to stop it. Soon after this, Judah’s leaders killed Amon around 640 BC. They made his son Josiah king in his place.

Josiah was only eight years old when he became king of Judah. He ruled for many years, from 640 to 609 BC. He was a righteous king. In the eighteenth year of his rule, workers were repairing the temple. During the repairs, a scroll of the Book of the Law was found (2 Kings 22:8; 2 Chronicles 34:14–15). After Josiah heard the law read to him, he led the people to return to God. He renewed their worship and brought back the religious practices God had commanded (2 Kings 23:1–25; 2 Chronicles 34:29–35:19).

Before this important event, most of the kingdom of Judah worshiped idols, as Manasseh and Amon had done. The people of Judah turned away from God so strongly that it finally led to their ruin (2 Kings 21:10–25; 2 Chronicles 33:17, 21–24).

Zephaniah prophesied early in Josiah’s rule. This was after Amon died and before the Book of the Law was found again. At that time, many people did not care about true worship. Leaders treated people unfairly, and many people wanted more wealth (Zephaniah 1:4–13; 3:1–4, 7). The people of Judah needed a true prophet of God, and Zephaniah was that kind of prophet. He may have helped prepare the people to accept Josiah’s major reforms.

Summary

Zephaniah starts his prophecy by announcing the Day of the LORD. This phrase means God’s coming judgment on the sinful world (1:2–3, 14–18). This

judgment would include God’s people in Judah and Jerusalem(1:4–13).

About 125 years earlier, the people of Israel in Amos’s time looked forward to the day of the Lord. They thought God would prove they were right by destroying their enemies. In the same way, the people of Judah may have expected God to protect them from judgment. But like Amos, Zephaniah had to warn his people. Their covenant relationship with God did not protect them from judgment if they continued to do evil.

The day of the Lord would come on all wicked people without favoritism. So Zephaniah urged the people of Judah to repent, seek the Lord, and live humbly in a right way (2:1–3). Then they might receive the Lord’s protection in the coming time of wrath.

The meaning of Zephaniah’s prophecy is clear. The nations near Judah would face terrible judgment. They had sinned against God’s people. They were proud and had rebelled against the Lord (2:4–15).

But Judah would not escape the Lord’s correction. Its religious and civil leaders knew God’s standards. Even so, they had led the people into deep corruption. The people of Judah also failed to learn from God’s judgment on other nations. Those nations had sinned in the same ways (3:1–7).

These coming judgments pointed to a future time when God would judge all nations on earth (3:8). But judgment would not be the end. The day of judgment would come so that a day of salvation could follow (3:9–20). God promised to restore and bless the faithful people of Israel who remained loyal to him. He also promised blessing for all peoples (3:9).

Zephaniah tells about God’s future plan to remove all proud people from the earth. Only those who “trust in the name of the LORD” will remain (3:12). God will gather his scattered people and bring them back to their land. There they will live in righteousness and safety, and they will worship the Lord (3:9–12).

The “remnant of Israel,” the faithful people of Israel who remain loyal to God, will receive God’s blessings (3:13–19). They will rejoice in him forever. The judgment and salvation in Zephaniah point forward to God’s final judgment and salvation when Jesus Christ returns (see Revelation 19:11–22:5).

Author

Little is known about Zephaniah beyond the family line in 1:1. This verse traces his family line to Hezekiah. This verse traces his family back to Hezekiah. Jewish

and Christian teachers have often understood this Hezekiah to be King Hezekiah (see 2 Kings 18:1–20:20). If this is correct, Zephaniah came from a royal family. He may also have had a good influence on young King Josiah. The list of four generations in 1:1 is unusual. At the least, it shows that Zephaniah came from an important family.

Zephaniah lived in Jerusalem and knew what was happening there (Zephaniah 1:10–13). He understood spiritual and moral problems clearly. He spoke against the people because they had turned away from God and were living in sin. He especially warned the leaders (1:4–6, 9, 17; 3:1–4, 7, 11).

Zephaniah also spoke against greed and love of wealth. These sins harmed the poor (1:8, 10–13, 18). He knew what was happening in the nations around Judah. He announced that God would judge those nations for their sins (2:4–15).

Above all, Zephaniah cared deeply about the Lord's reputation (1:6; 3:7). He also cared deeply about all people who humbly trust in God (2:3; 3:9, 12–13).

Date

Zephaniah himself said that his prophetic ministry took place during the time of Josiah, who ruled from 640 to 609 BC (see 1:1). Several facts suggest that Zephaniah prophesied early in Josiah's rule. This was before the Book of the Law was found and before Josiah's reforms began.

Zephaniah said that Judah still followed false religious practices from Canaanite worship. These practices were common during the time of Manasseh (1:4–5, 9). Many people did not worship the Lord at all (1:6). Leaders loved to wear the clothing of foreign merchants who had large businesses in Jerusalem (1:8; 1:10–11).

Judah's society also had many serious problems. The people faced social and economic injustice (1:12–13, 18). Their political and religious leaders were corrupt (3:1–4, 7, 11). Josiah's reforms corrected much of this around 622 BC (2 Kings 23:4–14). So Zephaniah probably gave his prophecy between 635 and 622 BC.

Meaning and Message

Like Nahum and Habakkuk, who prophesied during the same period, Zephaniah shows that God is the sovereign Lord over human history. This means God rules over all people and nations. God is the judge of all people (Zephaniah 1:2–3, 7, 14–18; 3:8). He punishes the evil actions of people (1:8–9, 17; 3:7, 11) and nations (2:4–15; 3:6). This sovereign Judge has chosen a time

when he will act in history. He will defeat evil and bring righteousness that lasts forever.

The day of the Lord will include all nations (1:2–4; 2:4–15; 3:8). God will show his wrath, or holy anger, when he judges humanity's sin and rebellion.

Zephaniah focuses on the basic problem of human pride (2:15). Pride leads people to turn away from God and do evil (1:3–6, 17; 3:1, 4). It also leads them to think that God will not act in human life (1:12).

Because of this, they continue to use violence and lies (1:9). Their greed also harms the people around them (1:10–11, 13, 18; 3:3).

God may remove the punishment that sinners deserve if they truly repent, or turn away from sin and return to him (2:1–3). But they must live with righteousness, humility, faith, and truth (3:12–13).

God will gather and purify a humble and faithful remnant, a small group of people who remain loyal to him (3:9–10). He will bring them back to their land (3:20) and give them victory over their enemies (2:7, 9). Jerusalem will be a joyful place (3:11, 18) because God will save and bless his people (3:14–20).

The New Testament also teaches that each person is responsible for sin (Romans 2:5–6; 2 Corinthians 5:10; Revelation 6:17; 19:11–21). God still gives his abundant grace, or undeserved kindness, to humble people (1 Peter 5:5–6). Through his grace, they can receive forgiveness of sin (Ephesians 1:7). They can also have the sure hope of everlasting life and blessing (Titus 3:4–7; Revelation 21:1–22:5).